

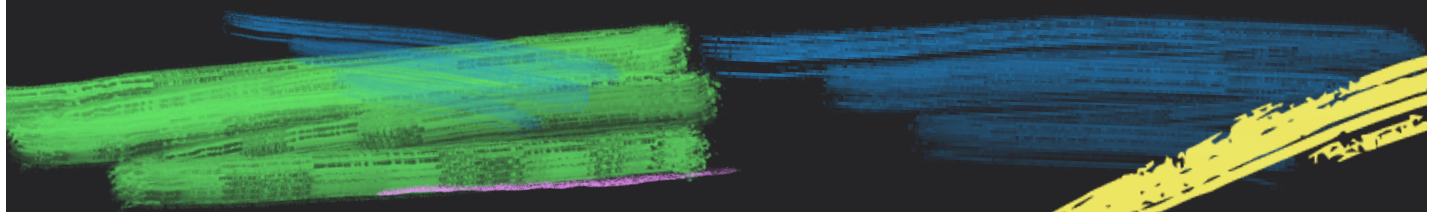


REACH, A BRAND OF REFRESH · PUBLIC-SERVING DIVISION

Know the Need

A summary. How a needs assessment people answer for themselves, connected directly to resources and case managers, gives every organization on REACH, from nonprofits and public agencies to employers at onboarding, an immediate read on what its people need and where to invest.

Summary · about an 8-minute read



What is in here. One idea, followed from a person's first five minutes, to what a nonprofit, a public agency, or an employer learns about the people it serves, to how the work gets paid for and what to call it. There is also a [PDF of this summary](#). For the network underneath it, read [the business case and strategic launch path](#).

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SECTION 1

The insight

Every organization that serves people gets the same question from its board, its funders, and its own leaders: what do the people we serve actually need? Today the honest answer is usually a guess. It gets assembled months later from intake forms, program enrollments, benefits utilization, and whoever asked for help loudly enough to be noticed.

One sentence. When a person answers fourteen plain questions about their own life, they see their next step in that moment, their organization sees the need as it forms, and REACH puts a resource or a case manager in front of them before they leave.

That joins four things that have always been kept apart: finding out what someone needs, getting them what they need, knowing what a whole community or workforce needs, and deciding where the next dollar should go. On REACH they happen in one motion.

SECTION 2

Community needs assessments exist. This is a different kind.

Assessing need is not new. Tax-exempt hospitals complete a Community Health Needs Assessment every three years, and Community Action agencies complete a community assessment on a similar cycle. Health systems use social-needs screeners such as PRAPARE and the CMS Accountable Health Communities screening tool. Human services agencies use self-sufficiency matrices, the best known being the Arizona Self-Sufficiency Matrix. Closed-loop referral platforms send and track referrals between agencies. Each is valuable, and each covers one part of the problem.

Community needs assessments

Describe a community

Surveys, focus groups, and public data, published every few years. They guide strategy, but they cannot help the person who answered.

Screeners

Find a risk

Usually a checklist that ends in a flag for staff. What happens next depends on who reads it, and when.

Matrices

Rate a household

Usually scored by a case manager inside one program and reported upward. The person rarely sees the result.

Referral platforms

Send a referral

Move a person between agencies, but only after someone else has decided what the need is.

What makes this one of a kind

THE PERSON PLACES THEMSELVES

Each of the fourteen areas asks one question with five answers in plain language, and the person picks the one that sounds like their life. Nobody scores them. Control over your own circumstances predicts how a life goes, so the assessment starts by handing that control back.

THE ANSWER IS THE FIRST STEP OF THEIR JOURNEY

Each answer sets the stage where the person's journey begins: Stabilize, Connect, Build Skills, or Maintain. Each stage already has three written steps with timeframes, roughly 630 across the fourteen areas. The person leaves already on their way, with a first step and a date, not a flag in someone else's queue.

ACCESS HAPPENS AT THE ANSWER

The area chooses the kind of resource, and the answer chooses how urgent it is. REACH, or the organization itself, then surfaces the resources and programs that fit, near enough to reach. Where nothing fits yet, the organization finds the resource or budgets for it, so it can be made available. The assessment is not a report about need. It is the search.

IT SHOWS WHERE TO INVEST

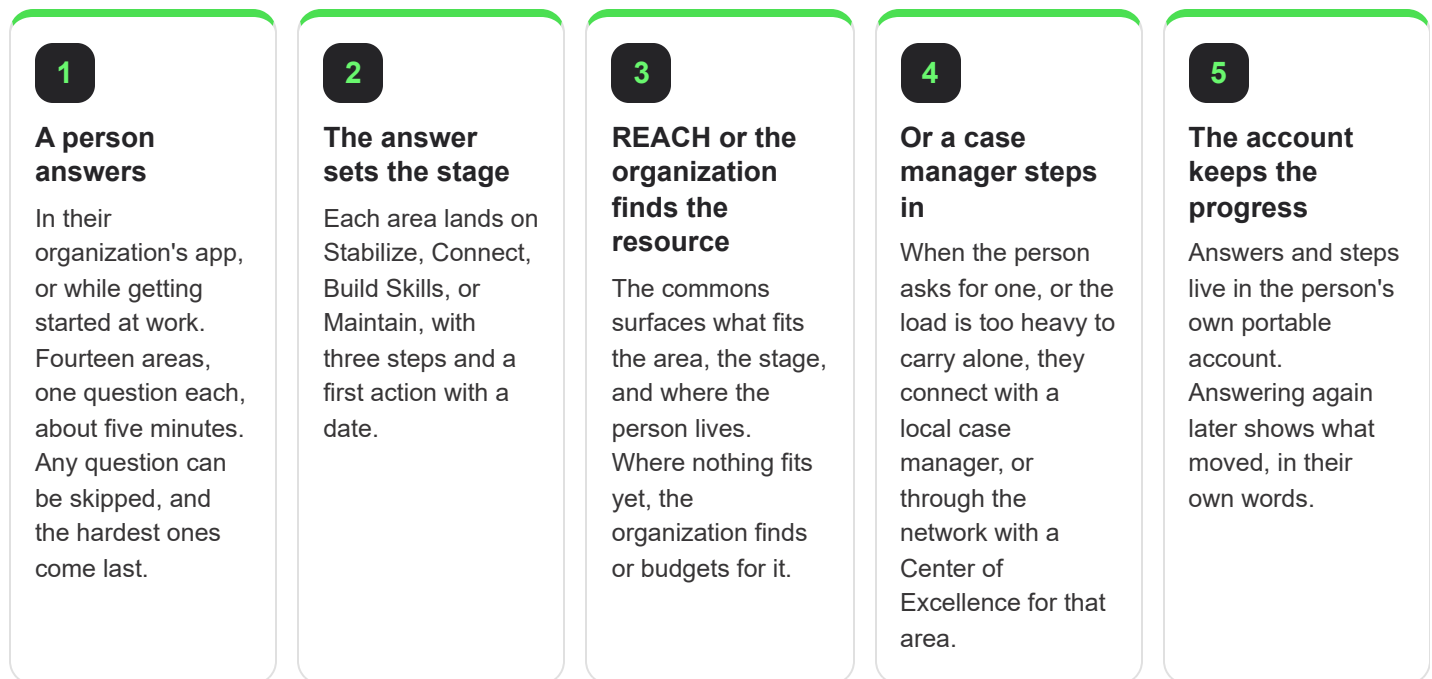
Pooled by area and by tag, the same answers tell a community, a nonprofit, or an employer which resources and programs to add, and for whom. A tag is a label on a person's account, such as where they came in, a site, or a program.

The claim we can defend. Community needs assessments describe a community after the fact, and screeners flag a person for someone else to act on. We have not found another personalized needs assessment that gives a person access to resources and programs the moment they answer and, from the same answers, tells the organization what to invest in next. If one exists, we want to learn from it.

SECTION 3

How it works, end to end

From where the person sits, they answered a few questions and left with help in hand. The machinery stays out of sight.



Three routes lead out of the same five minutes: a resource right away, a local case manager, or both. The person's choice decides.

A person is never a score. There is no total. Fourteen areas are fourteen results, and a level describes a situation, never a person.

Part of onboarding

The assessment belongs at the front door. When an organization joins REACH, its people take it as part of getting started, and the organization gets its first clear read on the people it serves in weeks rather than years.

Commercial customers

Total rewards built on the workforce you have

During onboarding, an employer learns what its workforce actually needs, from the physiological basics of food, housing, and a ride to work, up through mental health, family care, and connection. Work-life balance and overall wellbeing become visible instead of guessed at, so the total rewards budget goes to the benefits, perks, and supports this workforce will actually use.

REACH recipients

Know participants, community members, and volunteers

Public-sector agencies and nonprofits get the same read on the people they serve: participants, community members, volunteers, and their own staff. A community assessment done every few years gains a live companion, and every person who answered already has a next step.

Employers that give hourly and gig workers access to supports they would not otherwise have are already one of REACH's commercial buyers. The assessment gives that purchase a starting point, because it shows what to offer first and what can wait.

The line an employer never crosses. Answers belong to the employee. The employer sees pooled counts only, never a person and never a group small enough to point to one, and the answers are never used for hiring, pay, promotion, or discipline. Taking the assessment is voluntary. Health and mental health questions asked on behalf of an employer carry disability, health privacy, and wellness program rules, so counsel reviews any employer launch before it starts.

What the organization sees

Once people are answering, the same answers, pooled, tell an organization something it has never had in real time: what the people it serves need, area by area, this month.

Where the weight sits	Where the commons is thin	What moved
How many people are at Stabilize in Housing, or at Connect in Transportation, and whether that number is growing. Fourteen distributions, not one index.	The areas where people land at Stabilize and REACH has little nearby to offer. That tells the organization what to find or budget for, partners what to add, and funders what to fund.	Whether people who started at Stabilize reached Connect, by area and over time. This is the evidence funders and leadership increasingly ask for.

An example: 1,200 employees, one area

An employer with 1,200 employees onboards to REACH. In Nutrition, 600 of them, half the workforce, land at a stable level: they can steadily provide the food they and their families need. Only five answer that food isn't reliable right now. *The numbers are illustrative.*

What that changes. The obvious move would be bulletin boards about SNAP and case manager training on food assistance, and it would speak to almost no one. For this workforce the useful investment is eating well on a budget: recipes, healthy eating challenges, and help planning a food budget. The money that would have gone to a food assistance campaign can go to the area where the weight actually sits.

The five are not forgotten. Each one was linked to food help, and offered a case manager, privately, the moment they answered. The employer's view shows them as "fewer than 10," because a number that small could point to a person.

That is the case for fourteen distributions instead of one wellbeing score. A single index would have averaged the five into the six hundred and hidden both.

What exists today. The individual experience is written: the questions, the answers, the stages, and the steps. The pooled view is a design, not a finished product. It must show pooled counts only and never an individual, it must hide any group too small to keep people anonymous, and it must count only people who agreed to share. The account belongs to the person, and that does not change when their answers help a community or a workforce see itself.

SECTION 6

How it pays for itself

The assessment does not add a new cost. It points money that already exists at the right person sooner. Private, public, and restricted funding already pays for outreach, screening, and enrollment, and employers already budget for benefits and wellbeing. This puts that spending where the need is.

THE LOCAL AGENCY GAINS

Funded work, found sooner

- People who need what the agency is already funded to deliver find it sooner, and enroll when they are eligible
- Restricted grants can pay for the resource toolkit as procured technology, an allowable cost
- Outcome evidence that helps it renew and expand what it wins

THE CASE MANAGEMENT PROVIDER INVESTS

Curated marketing

- Shown to the people whose answers match what it does, by area, stage, and place
- Funds curated marketing on REACH, not a fee per referral
- Uses the resource toolkit with the people it serves

REFRESH EARNS

Marketing and tools, not referrals

- Curated marketing funded by case management providers
- Access to the resource toolkit
- Onboarding and platform fees from commercial customers

How curated marketing is priced is still open. **Decentralized Mission Services** sets out how agencies, funders, and people themselves pay for the services on the network.

The boundary that keeps this clean. Refresh facilitates and equips. It does not employ the case managers, does not set eligibility, and does not take a cut that varies with whether someone enrolls in a public benefit. Refresh is paid to market a case management provider to the people it can help, never for a referral. An answer on the assessment is never billable in itself, and counsel reviews how curated marketing is priced before any provider of a publicly reimbursed service takes part.

And the revenue follows the people. Organizations that hold a large, active, well-served population earn from it. The assessment is how that population learns what it needs, and a reason to keep coming back.

SECTION 7

What we will not do

Screen without a way to respond

Asking someone about food and then showing an empty list is extraction, not help. Launch where the commons can answer, and use the pooled view to fill the gaps.

Treat an answer as an emergency

A hard answer describes a situation, not a crisis. Emergencies come from what a person tells someone, and each organization's own crisis policy decides who responds.

Score, rank, or label people

No total, no ranking of people, and no level shown as who someone is. People know when they are being judged.

Show an employer one person's answers

Employers see pooled counts only, and nothing an employee answers is ever used in a decision about their job.

Sell referrals

Providers fund curated marketing. No one pays for a person.

Claim outcomes we have not measured

There is no outcome data yet. What we have is a design traceable to Marmot, Mullainathan and Shafir, Hicks, Desmond, and Schwartz, and to teams who have practiced this for a century.

SECTION 8

What to call it

Two things need names: what a person takes, and what an organization sees. Neither carries the REACH name. REACH is the grant program that pays for this on behalf of others, so the names belong to Refresh and to the person's own journey.

The family name

Refresh Personal Journeys is the working name for the whole experience: the questions, the stage each answer sets, and the steps that follow. It names what the person gets, a journey that is their own, rather than something done to them.

What a person takes

"Assessment" is accurate, but it reads like a test someone can fail. Each option below keeps the Personal Journeys name and changes that one word.

First choice, not decided	Alternative	Plain
Personal Journeys Check-In Warm, plain, and repeatable: you check in again later and see what moved. Works inside any organization's own app ("Goodwill Marion Check-In, powered by Refresh") and at work without needing an explanation.	Personal Journeys Starting Point Says exactly what the first answer is: the first step of the journey. Reads less naturally the second and third time someone answers.	Personal Journeys Assessment What funders, procurement teams, and RFPs already search for. Best kept for proposals and contracts rather than the screen a person sees.

Other words that work in place of "assessment" are **Journey Map**, which fits the journey idea, **Self-Check**, and **Profile**. Words to avoid are **screening**, which sounds like an eligibility test, **evaluation**, which sounds like judgment, and **snapshot**, because the point is a path forward, not a picture of what is wrong.

What an organization sees

Know the Need is the working name for the pooled view that a nonprofit, public agency, community, or employer sees. It is short, and it says what the view is for.

On "culture management." It fits the commercial side, where the buyer is HR and total rewards. It does not fit a person at a food pantry, who is not managing a culture. One answer is a single instrument with two labels: the Personal Journeys Check-In for people, and a culture and wellbeing view for employers. None of these names has had a trademark search.

Decisions this needs

THE POOLED VIEW

What organizations see, which tags they can filter by, the smallest group ever shown, how consent is asked, and who can see what. This needs a privacy review before any partner sees pooled answers.

EMPLOYER LAUNCH

Counsel's review of health and mental health questions offered through an employer, how voluntary participation is kept voluntary, and the smallest group an employer can see.

WHO GETS A CASE MANAGER

The rule that offers one, set against real case manager capacity in each market. The person's own choice always decides.

THE MODEL

How curated marketing is priced for case management providers, and counsel's review of it for providers of publicly reimbursed services.

ALL FOURTEEN, OR A SHORT FIRST PASS

Scarcity argues against asking fourteen questions of someone in crisis. The alternative is a short first pass, with more depth only where it is needed.

THE NAME

Which option in Section 8 people and partners see, followed by a trademark search.